“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 14

The Lord’s Infant Pastimes

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 “I worship Śrī Caitanya: when He is remembered in any way at all, the difficult becomes easy, and when He is forgotten, the opposite happens.” (Hari-bhakti-vilāsa 20.1)

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 I have told the *sūtra* of the Lord’s birth pastime—how Yaśodā’s son became the son of Śacī.

4 I have told the sequence of the birth pastime in brief; now I shall list the *sūtras* of the childhood pastimes.

5 I praise the enchanting childhood pastimes of Caitanya-Kṛṣṇa: though they seem humanlike, within they are filled with the deeds of the Lord.

6 In His childhood pastimes the Lord first lay on His back and showed His father and mother the marks on His feet.

7 In the house the two saw the prints of small feet, and in them were a flag, a thunderbolt, a conch, a disc and a fish.

8 Seeing them, both were filled with wonder: whose footprints could be in the house? They could not be sure.

9 Miśra said, “Bāla-gopāla is here with our *śālagrāma-śilā*. I think He takes a form and plays about the house for fun.”

10 At that moment Nimāi woke and began to cry. Śacī took Him on her lap and nursed Him.

11 As she nursed Him she looked at her son’s feet and, seeing those very marks on them, she called Miśra.

12 Seeing them, Miśra rejoiced and secretly called Nīlāmbara Cakravartī.

13 Seeing the marks, Cakravartī said with a smile, “When I calculated His ascendant earlier, I wrote all this down.

14 There are thirty-two marks that adorn a great personality, and I see all of them on this child’s body.

15 “A great personality bears thirty-two marks: five parts of his body are long, five fine, seven reddish and six raised; three are short, three broad and three deep.”

16 His holy hands and feet bear the marks of Nārāyaṇa. This child will deliver all people.

17 He will preach Vaiṣṇava *dharma*, and through Him both families will be delivered.

18 Hold a great festival and invite all the brāhmaṇas. Today is an auspicious day; I shall perform the naming ceremony.

19 He will support and nourish all people; that is why His name is Viśvambhara, ‘He who sustains the universe.’”

20 Hearing this, Śacī and Miśra grew still more joyful. They invited brāhmaṇas and their wives and held a festival.

21 After some days the Lord began crawling on His knees, and then He showed many wonders.

22 On the pretext of crying He made people chant the name of Hari: all the women said “Hari,” and the golden Lord laughed.

23 After some days more He began to walk, and joining the other children He played many games.

24 One day Śacī brought puffed rice and sweets, filled a dish, gave it to Him and said, “Sit down and eat.”

25 With these words Śacī went off to do her housework, and the child secretly began to eat earth.

26 Seeing this, Śacī came running, crying “Alas! Alas!” She snatched the earth away and said, “Why are You eating earth?”

27 Weeping, the child said, “Why are you angry? You gave Me earth to eat —what fault is it of Mine?

28 Puffed rice, sweets, grains—all are transformations of earth. This is earth, that is earth; what difference is there?

29 The body is earth, the food is earth—consider and see. You blame Me without thinking; what can I say?”

30 Astonished at heart, Śacī said to Him, “Who taught You this yoga of knowledge so that You may eat earth?

31 Food, a transformation of earth, nourishes the body when eaten; but if you eat earth itself, you fall ill and the body wastes away.

32 In a pot, which is a transformation of earth, I fill and carry water; but when I pour water on a lump of earth, it soaks away.”

33 To hide Himself, the Lord said to her, “Mother, why didn’t you teach Me this before?

34 Now I know it, and I will not eat earth any more. When I am hungry, I will drink at your breast.”

35 Saying this, the Lord climbed onto His mother’s lap and, smiling slightly, drank at her breast.

36 In this way, on various pretexts, He revealed His majesty, and then hid it again by showing a child’s ways.

37 He ate a guest brāhmaṇa’s offering three times, and afterwards, in secret, He delivered that brāhmaṇa.

38 Finding the Lord outside, thieves carried Him off; riding on their shoulders, He bewildered them and came back home.

39 On the pretext of illness He ate Viṣṇu’s offering in the homes of Jagadīśa and Hiraṇya on the day of Ekādaśī.

40 He would go with the children into the neighbors’ houses, steal food and eat it, and beat the other boys.

41 The children all complained to Śacī, and hearing them, she scolded her son a little:

42 “Why do You steal? Why do You beat the children? Why do You go to other people’s houses—what is there that we don’t have at home?”

43 Hearing this, the Lord grew angry, went into the house and smashed all the pots that were there.

44 Then Śacī took Him on her lap and soothed Him, and the Lord became ashamed, knowing His fault.

45 Once He struck His mother with His soft hand; seeing her faint, He began to cry.

46 The women said, “Bring a coconut, and then Your mother will be well.”

47 He went outside and brought back two coconuts. Everyone was astonished to see such a wonder.

48 Once He was bathing in the Gaṅgā with the children, and the girls came there to worship the gods.

49 After bathing in the Gaṅgā they began their worship, and the Lord came and sat down among the girls.

50 He said to the girls, “Worship Me, and I will give you a boon. Gaṅgā and Durgā are My maidservants, and Maheśa is My servant.”

51 He Himself put on the sandalwood paste and the flower garlands, snatched the offerings and ate them—the sweets, the rice and the bananas.

52 The girls said angrily, “Listen, Nimāi! By village relationship You are a brother to us all.

53 It isn’t proper for us to say this, but do not take the gods’ offerings, and do not do wrong!”

54 The Lord said, “I have given you all this boon: each of you will have a most handsome husband,

55 learned, clever, young and rich in wealth and grain; each of you will have seven sons, long-lived and intelligent.”

56 Hearing the boon, the girls were delighted at heart, but outwardly they scolded Him in feigned anger.

57 One girl ran off with her offerings, and the Lord, angry, called after her:

58 “If you are miserly and do not give Me the offerings, you will have an old husband and four co-wives!”

59 Hearing this, they all grew afraid: “Perhaps He knows something, or a god has entered Him.”

60 They brought the offerings and held them out before Him; He ate the offerings and gave them the boons they desired.

61 In this way He displayed His pranks to everyone; no one was troubled at heart, and all were made happy.

62 One day Vallabhācārya’s daughter, named Lakṣmī, came to worship the gods after bathing in the Gaṅgā.

63 Seeing her, the Lord's heart was drawn to her, and Lakṣmī felt joy at heart on seeing the Lord.

64 Their natural love awakened; though their bodies were still veiled in childhood, it became firm.

65 Seeing each other, both rejoiced at heart, and under the pretext of worshipping the gods they revealed their feelings.

66 The Lord said, "Worship Me—I am Maheśvara, the Supreme Lord. If you worship Me, you will obtain the boon you desire."

67 Lakṣmī offered flowers and sandalwood paste on His body, placed a garland of *mallikā* flowers on Him and bowed down.

68 Receiving her worship, the Lord began to smile, and reciting a verse He accepted her feelings.

69 "O chaste ones, I know your resolve to worship Me. I approve of it, and it deserves to come true." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 10.22.25)

70 After this pastime the two went home. Who can understand the deep pastimes of Caitanya?

71 Seeing Caitanya's pranks, everyone would complain to Śacī and Jagannātha out of love.

72 One day Śacī-devī scolded her son and went to catch Him, but He ran away.

73 Lord Viśvambhara sat happily on top of the discarded pots in the refuse pit.

74 Śacī came and said, “Why have You touched impure things? You have become impure—go and bathe in the Gaṅgā.”

75 Hearing this, He told His mother about the knowledge of Brahman. His mother was astonished, but she made Him bathe.

76 Once, as Śacī lay down with her son, she saw divine beings come and fill the house.

77 Śacī said, “Go, son, call your father.” At His mother’s bidding the Lord went outside.

78 As He walked, ankle-bells jingled on His feet, and His father and mother were amazed to hear them.

79 Miśra said, “This is very wonderful! Why is there a sound of ankle-bells on the child’s bare feet?”

80 Śacī said, “I saw another wonder: divine beings came and filled the courtyard.

81 I could not understand what they were saying so loudly. I suppose they were praising someone.”

82 Miśra said, “Whatever it may be, there is nothing to worry about. All I want is Viśvambhara’s well-being.”

83 One day, seeing his son’s pranks, Miśra instructed Him in *dharma* and scolded Him severely.

84 That night he saw in a dream a brāhmaṇa who came and spoke angry words to him:

85 “Miśra, you know nothing of the truth about your son. You scold and beat Him because you consider Him your son.”

86 Miśra said, “Let Him be a god, a perfected being or a sage—why not? However great He may be, now He is my son.

87 To bring up and teach his son is a father’s duty. If I do not teach Him, how will He know the essence of *dharma*?”

88 The brāhmaṇa said, “But if He is divinely perfect, His knowledge is complete by itself, and then teaching is useless.”

89 Miśra said, “Even if my son is Nārāyaṇa—why not?—still, it is a father’s *dharma* to teach his son.”

90 In this way the two discussed *dharma*. Miśra had pure parental love and knew nothing else.

91 Hearing this, the brāhmaṇa went away pleased, and Miśra woke up utterly astonished.

92 He told the dream to his friends and relatives, and everyone who heard it was astonished.

93 Thus Gauracandra played His childhood pastimes, and day by day His parents’ joy increased.

94 After some days Miśra placed chalk in his son’s hand, and in a few days He learned the letters with their twelve compound signs.

95 I have told in sequence the *sūtra* of the childhood pastimes; Vṛndāvana dāsa has described them in detail.

96 Therefore I have given the childhood pastimes briefly, as a *sūtra*; for fear of repetition I have not told them at length.

97 Hoping for the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Raghunātha, Kṛṣṇadāsa tells the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.